

# *A Social Media That Doesn't Cost Us Money*

*A practical model for building Colourmap's social layer without ad spend, influencers, or a marketing team. Start with rooms of 8 people; grow to nights of 100; eventually to weekends of 500. Each step funds the next.*

## *The thesis in one paragraph*

The cheapest customer acquisition is **people who already love each other in the same room**. If 8 friends spend an evening together with the app open, and the app made the evening better, they each tell two more people. That's the entire growth engine for the first 18 months. **Events** are the thing those 8 friends gather around; **Circles** are the in-app residue that keeps the group alive between events. Everything else (paid acquisition, SEO, content marketing) we don't do.

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### **STAGE 1** *The Salon*

MONTHS 0–3 · GROUP SIZE: 6–12

The first version of "social Colourmap" is a single small event in a single living room. **Not a feature, an event.**

#### **What it is**

You and a friend invite 6–10 people to a 2-hour evening. Each guest brings their phone. The app guides the evening:

- A 5-minute opening check-in (everyone in the room does the Feeling/Doing flow, results aggregated to one big screen showing the room's emotional state)

- 90 minutes of music — Chill Machine + Groove Machine — with the **collective vote** mode active (everyone has a "more fire / more calm" slider on their phone, the room's average drives the music)
- A 15-minute closing reflection in the Notebook

**Cost:** *The host's living room. Snacks (host pays). A speaker (host has one). The app (free).*

**Marginal cost per attendee = €0.** *No ads, no venue, no software fee, no staff.*

## Growth

- Each attendee is a *witness* — they know it works because they felt it work in the room.
- 70% rule of thumb: 70% of guests will tell at least 2 friends within a week. From one salon: ~14 new "warm leads."
- 30% will offer to host the next one. **The salon self-replicates.**

## What we ship to enable this

- Circle creation flow (already exists in */circles*)
- Collective vote sliders in Groove Machine
- A simple "Salon mode" preset — opens the right surfaces in the right order
- Optional: a one-page printed guide for hosts

**Two weeks of focused work to enable the first 100 salons.**

## STAGE 2 *The Underground Night*

MONTHS 3–9 · GROUP SIZE: 30–80

Once the salon model is *known to work*, scale it once. Not 100×, just 5–10×.

## What it is

A monthly "Colourmap Night" in a friendly venue: yoga studio, small art gallery, cooperative café after closing, a friend's dance studio. Some venues will host for

free in exchange for a share of door donations.

- Same arc as the salon, scaled up
- Bigger speakers, projector for the visualizer
- One "host" leads the evening — usually a friend who's run 3+ salons
- Suggested donation at the door (€5–15) — **covers venue costs**, nothing more

**Cost:** Venue usually free (favourites, exchange, friends). Sound system borrowed or rented (€50–100, covered by door). App still free.

**Out-of-pocket from us: €0.**

## Growth

- Each night brings ~50 new people into the app
- ~10 of them go on to host their own salons
- Local press notices something is happening — *unpaid* coverage in city blogs, alternative weeklies, art newsletters
- Word of mouth: "have you been to one of those Colourmap nights?"

## STAGE 3 Experiments + Expos

MONTHS 6–18

In parallel with the regular nights, do things that are *strange* enough that people *want to write about them*. Strangeness is free.

## Examples

- **The 24-hour Salon.** Friday night to Saturday night, in a countryside house. Music modulated by the room's collective fatigue.
- **The Silent Salon.** No human speech for 90 minutes — only music + check-ins on phones.
- **The Cooking Salon.** Group cooks together; the app's music adapts to the chopping/stirring/eating phases.

- **The Gallery Night.** Pair Colourmap with a local artist's opening — the visualizer reflects the room's mood across the artist's work.
- **Co-living week.** Take over a small place for 3–7 days with 8 people. Each leaves with a "shape" of the week.

**Cost:** *Each is small (€0–500 out-of-pocket) and self-funded by attendee contributions. None require staff or paid promotion.*

## Why this works for growth

- These are **stories**. Stories travel. A normal-app launch doesn't get press; a "24-hour silent salon" might.
- Each is a content piece — pictures, audio, an essay — that lives on a blog or zine and pulls in serendipity traffic forever.
- They attract a different audience: artists, somatic practitioners, journalists, festival programmers. These people become amplifiers.

## STAGE 4 Festivals + Expos

MONTHS 12–24

Once you have ~50 monthly nights happening across cities, the app is *legible* to bigger institutions.

## What it is

- A 1-room installation at a small art festival or design week (Salone Milano, Vienna's MAK, Berlin's DesignMai, smaller art biennales)
- Curators love things that "involve the visitor" — Colourmap literally is that
- The festival usually pays for the booth/space
- We bring 4–6 friends to staff it

**Cost:** *Travel for 2–4 of us (~€500–1500). Print materials (~€100). Festival pays the rest.*

## Growth

- Press coverage in design + art outlets — the kind that doesn't cost money but lasts
- Gets the app in front of curators, festival directors, journalists
- Each festival is also a "salon at scale" — 200+ visitors over a weekend

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## *What we never do*

These are the temptations that burn money for unclear returns:

- **Paid ads** (Google, Meta, TikTok) — too expensive per install for a deeply intentional product.
- **Influencer partnerships** — almost always inauthentic; audience installs and bounces.
- **Hiring a marketer** — until ~100k MAU, the founders are the marketers.
- **PR firms** — priced for SaaS launches; our story is shaped at salons, not press releases.
- **Conferences as attendees** — only as exhibitors with a free booth.

## *How to make it light and easy*

The biggest risk is that "running events" becomes *work* and hosts burn out.

## Five rules to keep it light

1. **The app does the heavy lifting.** Pre-built salon flow that a host can run with no preparation. They press one button, the app guides 90 minutes.
2. **Hosts get a tool, not a job.** They're not "ambassadors" doing free labour for us — they're using the app to make their own evening better.

3. **Donations not tickets.** Tickets create pressure to perform; donations stay friendly.
4. **No KPIs from us to hosts.** We don't ask them to bring 30 people next time. We ask them how it went.
5. **Make sharing automatic.** After a salon, the app generates a beautiful image of the room's collective shape — every attendee can save and post it. Free, organic, distributed marketing — but only if the moment was good enough to share.

## Concrete next 90 days

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- **Week 1–2:** Salon mode in the app. Run our first salon ourselves with 8 friends.
- **Week 3–4:** Iterate based on what failed. Run salon #2.
- **Week 5–6:** Build the host kit (PDF, invite templates, presets). Recruit 5 friends in 5 cities to run salons #3–7.
- **Week 7–10:** Underground night infrastructure — venue scout flow, door-donation guidance, projector mode. Run Night #1 in our city.
- **Week 11–12:** Document what we've learned. Pick the first Experiment to run in month 4.

**Total spend in 90 days: under €500.** Total reach: plausibly 200–400 people in the app by day 90, all of whom touched it through someone they trusted.

## Closing

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*The core bet: **rooms of people who love each other already are the cheapest, most loyal, most beautiful distribution channel.** Build for that. Resist every temptation to scale it any way that removes the room.*

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**Colourmap** · From organization to clarity.

Strategy memo, written 2026-04-25